

AYE CAPTAIN
PM Modi being sworn in by President Droupadi Murmu, Jun. 9

HINDUSTAN TIMES

marked by the fact that GDP growth slowed down to 5.4 per cent in the second quarter of FY25—a worrying dip of 2.2 per cent compared to the same period the previous year. It is now abundantly clear that it cannot be business as usual when the new year dawns and Budget 2025 will have to reflect that urgency.

On the international front too, India faced diplomatic headwinds in 2024, particularly in relations with our troubled neighbourhood. Modi made it a point to invite major South Asian leaders to the swearing-in (barring Pakistan's new dispensation), signalling what would be his top priority in the third term. Employing a carrot-and-threat policy, Modi neutralised the regime change in Maldives which was swinging decisively towards China after President Mohamed Muizzu won the election on an 'India Out' campaign. India played its cards right in Sri Lanka by engaging all the political combatants before the elections there, including the eventual winner, Anura Kumara Dissanayake. But we were caught wrongfooted when popular protests ousted long-time ally Sheikh Hasina in Bangladesh in August. While relations with Bhutan remained upbeat, Nepal seemed to be sliding towards China under the K.P.S. Oli dispensation. However, Modi effected a surprising breakthrough in India-China relations by getting Beijing to back off from its aggressive manoeuvres on the Line of Actual Control in the Ladakh sector, thereby all but ending the dangerous four-year-old stand-off between the world's two most populous countries.

Meanwhile, with two big international wars—Russia and Ukraine in Europe and Israel-Hamas in the Middle East—continuing to afflict 2024, Modi trod a fine line to secure India's national interests even as he upheld international principles of territorial sovereignty and pushed for "a path of peace through dialogue". He played a deft balancing act by giving Russian president Vladimir Putin a bear hug but retained India's neutrality by being the first PM to visit Ukraine and putting a consoling arm around president Volodymyr Zelenskyy. The balanced approach was evident in the Israel conflict too, with India condemning the Hamas terror strikes but also advocating for the two-state solution in support of Palestine.

There were diplomatic setbacks with Canada openly accusing Indian agencies of assassinating Sikh separatists and the US piling on a similar charge. Despite these hiccups, Modi ensured that relations with the US continued to prosper, especially in the areas of defence and critical emerging technologies. With Donald Trump the next president-elect, Modi, who got along with him well in his first term, needs to build on the strong relations the two countries have nurtured. Given Trump's mercurial nature, this will be a tough ask in the new year. All in all, what 2024 brought to the fore was Modi's immense resilience despite setbacks, his continuing dominance over the political narrative and his resolute pursuit of making India a developed nation by doing whatever it takes to get us there. ■

In 2024, Modi showed immense resilience despite setbacks, and continued his dominance over the political narrative